always myself. I regard myself as very fortunate to have that gift, because there are a lot of people who struggle to chat and mix with strangers.

The teachers at Bishops took a shining to me too. They must have, or else I don't know how I managed to make it through high school. Ja, I was no great shakes academically. When it came to the actual studying side of things, I was way out of my depth. I reckon they just let me pass every year.

Except Standard 9. They kept me back then – perhaps they wanted me to play sport for them for another year. I reckon, though, that I never properly passed a year of high school. I have to mention, however, that I did once get 93 per cent for a business economics exam in Standard 8. No idea how that happened – it's not like I cheated or got hold of the paper beforehand. In fact, I've only ever 'cheated' once – or, more accurately, was involved in an underhand activity. And, as everyone knows, that got me into all kinds of trouble. But more about that later.

I remember that I actually enjoyed business economics as a subject, so perhaps that's why I did well in the exam. I also always passed English and Afrikaans, but I found it a monumental schlep to study history or geography. And biology … man, I just couldn't understand why the hell we needed to take that subject. As it turns out, I would become very, very interested in biology later in life.

My dad pushed me a bit to try to improve my marks. When I was younger, he was a teacher and therefore fairly strict when it came to my studies. He taught physical education and a bit of history at a school called Bridgetown High in Athlone. Apparently he was very strict. I hear people used to genuinely kak themselves in his class. So my dad tried to encourage me to work harder and do better, even though he could see I obviously wasn't enjoying it. My head just wasn't focused on my books. My head was on the sports field and, increasingly, on girls.

We lived in Elfindale in Cape Town's southern suburbs, and I used to catch the train to school each day. Rondebosch Station was one of the stops. I used to check out all the hot girls there, then get off at the next station, catch the train back and check them out again. If there was someone I felt I needed to get to know a little better, I'd jump off and make a concerted effort to get her contact details. Obviously it meant I'd often be late for school, but I didn't give a damn – I'd blame it on the trains running late. What could they do? Certainly no one on the Bishops staff took the train, so they could only take my word for it.